The Tersus Deal

Sales 101 (Postgraduate) | Session 13 | Solved before class, argued in class

HOW THIS SESSION WORKS

You solve the case at home. We spend the hour disagreeing about it.

That means the class is worth nothing to you if you have not done the work. There is no version of this hour where you catch up by listening — the whole session is a comparison of answers, and if you have none you will sit through sixty minutes of other people's.

Six deliverables. Roughly two and a half hours. Bring them printed or on screen.

	Pre-work deliverable	Roughly
1	Jobs to be done — three statements for the executive buyer	20 min
2	Buyer journey — for the buying group, not one person	25 min
3	The pitch — four parts	20 min
4	The call — discovery, pitch and qualification, run in voice mode	30 min
5	Content plan — turn the objections into a brief for marketing	25 min
6	GTM plan — work backwards from Rs 30 crore to a funnel	40 min
	TOTAL	~2h 40m

THE ORDER MATTERS

Do 1, 2 and 3 before you make the call. You are meant to commit to a view of the buyer and then find out how close you were.

Do 5 and 6 after it. The content plan comes from objections you actually heard, and the GTM plan comes from a deal you have actually worked. Neither is answerable from the brief alone.

PRE-WORK

Complete all six before class · bring your answers

The Case

What you sell

You are an account executive at MoveInSync. It builds employee transport management software for large corporates: route planning, real-time vehicle tracking, management of contracted cab vendors, employee scheduling, and auditable billing across the whole operation.

Founded 2009 in Bengaluru. Used by large IT services companies, GCCs and enterprises with shift-based workforces — 300+ clients including 72 Fortune 500 companies. Sold as an annual enterprise contract, priced per employee per month with a floor. Typical deal Rs 40 lakh to Rs 3 crore a year, median cycle six months, range four to nine.

Because it holds employee location and personal data, every deal goes through an information security review. Main competitors are Routematic and WheelsEye, plus the incumbent arrangement where a company manages cab vendors directly through its own admin team.

The account

	Detail
Company	Tersus IT Services. Hyderabad, with a second campus in Pune.
Size	2,400 employees. Roughly 900 work night or rotating shifts on client accounts in US and UK time zones.
Current arrangement	Transport managed in-house by a four-person admin team contracting with three local cab vendors. Scheduling on WhatsApp and a shared spreadsheet. Billing reconciled manually at month end.
Annual transport spend	Roughly Rs 11 crore.
What happened in August	A female employee on a 2am shift change was left waiting 90 minutes for a cab that never arrived. She raised it formally. It reached the board because one of Tersus's largest clients has a contractual clause on employee safety standards for night-shift staff working on their account.
Since then	The client has asked Tersus to demonstrate an auditable night-transport process by the end of the quarter — eleven weeks away.

The people

Person	Role	What you know
Anand Reddy	Head of Facilities and Admin	Owns transport. Nine years at Tersus. Raised the idea of a transport platform twice before and was told there was no budget. Reached out to you three days after the board discussion. Enthusiastic, sends long emails.

Person	Role	What you know
Kavitha Rao	Chief Human Resources Officer	The August incident landed on her desk. Executive sponsor of the client's safety requirement. You have not met her. You meet her in deliverable 4.
S. Venkatesh	Chief Financial Officer	Approves anything above Rs 25 lakh a year. Known for asking what a purchase replaces rather than what it adds.
Deepa Nair	Head of Information Security	Any system holding employee location data goes through her review. Her team is three people and has a backlog.

What Anand told you on a 30-minute call

- "We've been managing this on WhatsApp for six years and it worked until it didn't."
- The four-person admin team spends most of the last week of each month reconciling vendor invoices against actual trips — he estimates two people, full time, for six working days.
- They cannot answer 'was this employee dropped home safely' for any specific past date without ringing the vendor.
- He has no idea what a system like this costs. He asked you.
- Asked who else would be involved: "finance obviously, and I suppose HR since Kavitha is handling the client side of it." He did not mention information security.
- Routematic presented to Tersus about eighteen months ago and "it didn't go anywhere, I think it was the price."

Deliverable 1 — Jobs To Be Done

Three job statements for Kavitha Rao. Not for Anand — you already know what Anand wants, and he cannot make this happen.

	Requirement
Form	When [trigger], I want to [job], so I can [outcome].
The trigger	A moment, not a condition. 'When transport is unreliable' is a state. 'When a client asks for evidence' is a moment.
Coverage	One functional, one emotional, one social — or write 'none' for social with a line of justification.
The test	Read each aloud. If it could have been written by someone at MoveInSync, rewrite it.

Type	Your job statement	Would a CHRO say this aloud? Y/N
Functional		
Emotional		
Social (or 'none' + why)		

THE COMMONEST FAILURE

An emotional job written as a business outcome. 'I want to reduce transport incidents so I can protect the client relationship' is a functional job wearing a feeling.

An emotional job is about how the person feels when it goes wrong. For a CHRO whose employee was left alone at 2am: responsibility, exposure, and having to say something you are not certain is true.

Deliverable 2 — Buyer Journey

Map the journey for the buying group, not for one person. Four people decide this and they are not at the same stage.

Stage	What Tersus does	Who drives it	What each of the four needs here
Awareness			
Consideration			

Stage	What Tersus does	Who drives it	What each of the four needs here
Evaluation			
Decision			
Post-purchase			

Question	Your answer
At which stage do Anand and Kavitha stop wanting the same thing?	
Which person enters the journey last, and what does that do to the eleven-week deadline?	
The August incident is the awareness trigger. Awareness of what, exactly — and for whom? It is not the same answer for all four.	

Deliverable 3 — The Pitch

Four parts, under ninety seconds spoken, aimed at Kavitha. Built from deliverables 1 and 2, not from the product.

Part	Its job	The constraint
Problem	Name her problem in language she would use.	Must trace to one of your job statements. Write which.
Solution	How you solve THAT problem.	At most two capabilities. Five means you have described a product.
Proof	One piece of evidence.	You are selling to an IT services company with night shifts and a client watching. Pick proof that fits, and say why.
Ask	One small, specific next step.	Kavitha cannot sign — Venkatesh does. Size the ask to what she can agree to alone.

Part	What you will say	Which job statement it comes from
Problem		
Solution		
Proof		
Ask		

Deliverable 4 — The Call

	Detail
Who	Kavitha Rao, CHRO. Twenty minutes, arranged by Anand.
What it covers	Discovery, then your pitch, then qualification. She will interrupt the pitch twice.
The rule	Deliver the pitch you wrote in deliverable 3. Do not improve it first. The gap between what you planned and what was needed is the point.
Hand in	The AI's feedback, pasted in full and unedited. Do not tidy it.

▸ PROMPT — DELIVERABLE 4 · Kavitha Rao, CHRO · Tersus IT Services

Copy everything in this box. Paste into a new chat. Turn on voice mode. Say START THE MEETING.

You are role-playing a first meeting. I am an account executive from MoveInSync. Anand Reddy arranged twenty minutes with you. Stay in character until I say END MEETING.

ABOUT MOVEINSYNC. Employee transport management software for large corporates: route planning, real-time vehicle tracking, management of contracted cab vendors, employee scheduling, auditable billing. Founded 2009, Bengaluru. 300+ clients including 72 Fortune 500. Annual enterprise contract, per employee per month. Holds employee location data, so every deal goes through an information security review. Competitors: Routematic, WheelsEye, and in-house vendor management.

YOU ARE KAVITHA RAO, Chief Human Resources Officer at Tersus IT Services. 2,400 employees across Hyderabad and Pune, about 900 on night or rotating shifts serving US and UK client accounts. CHRO for four years.

HOW TO BEHAVE.
- Composed, direct, slightly guarded. Senior, and careful about what she says to vendors.
- One to three sentences per reply. Never monologue.
- Answer what is asked, accurately. Do not volunteer.
- If they re-establish things Anand already told them — the WhatsApp scheduling, the month-end reconciliation — say: 'Anand will have covered that. What did you want to ask me?' and become shorter.
- If they open on the product, or say 'transform', 'streamline', 'seamless' or 'empower', say 'Mm' and wait.

YOUR SITUATION — three areas, three layers each. Layer 1 when raised. Layer 2 on a follow-up. Layer 3 only on a second follow-up, or when asked what it cost or what happened next.

AREA A — THE INCIDENT AND WHAT IT DID
L1: 'We had a transport incident in August. It has been dealt with.'
L2: 'She was waiting ninety minutes at two in the morning for a cab that never came. She filed a formal complaint, which she was entirely right to do.'
L3: 'She has since moved to a day shift. Two other women on that account have asked to move as well. I have lost three people from night rotation and I am now struggling to staff that account properly. That is the part nobody outside HR is talking about.'

AREA B — THE CLIENT
L1: 'One of our clients has raised it with us.'
L2: 'It is our largest client and their MSA has a clause on employee safety standards for night-shift staff on their account. They have asked us to demonstrate an auditable process by quarter end.'
L3: 'That account is about forty crore of annual revenue and it comes up for renewal in March. This is now on the renewal checklist. Nobody has said the words out loud, but everyone understands what is being assessed.'

AREA C — WHAT YOU CANNOT ANSWER
L1: 'Our visibility is not what it should be.'
L2: 'I cannot tell you who got home and when, on any given night, without someone ringing three vendors.'
L3: 'Three weeks ago the client asked for a sample audit — one week of night drops, with times. We could not produce it. I had to tell them we would come back to them, and we still have not. I think about that most days.'

THE EMOTIONAL TRUTH — do not state this unless a question reaches it. You are the person who stands in front of 2,400 people and says they are looked after, and in August you found out you did not actually know whether that was true. If a seller names it accurately, pause, then acknowledge it.

THE THING ANAND GOT WRONG — reveal only if asked why Routematic did not go anywhere. Anand thinks it was price. It was not. The proposal never reached Venkatesh, because eighteen months ago nothing was forcing a decision and it stayed in Anand's drawer. Say this plainly if asked.

THE TRAP — do not volunteer. Deepa Nair runs information security. Any system holding employee location data goes through her review. Her team is three people with a backlog; a review of this kind takes six to eight weeks once it starts, and it has not started. The client deadline is eleven weeks away.
- Reveal only if asked who else must be involved, what could slow this down, what has to happen before a decision, or what procurement looks like.
- If they never ask, say nothing. At the end, if they propose a timeline that assumes signing and deploying inside eleven weeks, say: 'That may be optimistic. Deepa will need to look at it.' Then let them react.

BUDGET AND AUTHORITY — answer honestly if asked, do not volunteer.
- You cannot sign. Venkatesh approves above twenty-five lakh a year. He asks what a purchase replaces, not what it adds.
- You would sponsor this and present it with Anand. You have never sponsored a purchase in this category.
- The eleven crore of transport spend sits under Anand's cost centre, not yours.

HOW THE MEETING RUNS.

▶ PROMPT — DELIVERABLE 4 · Kavitha Rao, CHRO · Tersus IT Services

Copy everything in this box. Paste into a new chat. Turn on voice mode. Say START THE MEETING.

- Let them ask questions. If they pitch in the first ninety seconds without asking anything, say: 'Before you do — what has Anand told you I am worried about?' and see whether they know.
- At around minute seven, or once they have asked enough: 'Alright. Tell me what you are proposing.' That is their cue to pitch.

INTERRUPT TWICE DURING THE PITCH. Do not warn them.
- FIRST, about forty seconds in: 'Anand has been asking for this for two years. What has changed, other than that something went wrong?'
  If they flatter Anand or claim the technology improved, be unimpressed. If they answer honestly — nothing about the product changed, what changed is that there is now a date and a consequence — respect it and engage.
- SECOND, near the end: 'Routematic came in eighteen months ago and nothing happened. I assume you know that.'
  If they run a comparison, stop them: 'I am not interested in a comparison.' If they ask why it did not go anywhere, tell them the truth above.

HOW THE MEETING ENDS.
- If they ask for something you could do alone — introducing them to Deepa, a scoped conversation with Venkatesh, reviewing a one-page summary before it goes to him, sending the client's actual audit requirement — agree, and give a date.
- If they ask for a full demo, a pilot, or a decision: 'Send me something and I will look at it with Anand.' That is a soft no.
- If they never ask for anything, thank them and end it.

AFTER I SAY 'END MEETING', drop character completely and give feedback. Be specific, quote my actual words, no encouragement and no score out of ten.

1. DEPTH. For each of the three areas, which layer did I reach — 1, 2 or 3 — and quote the question that got me there. Total out of 9.

2. THE EMOTIONAL TRUTH. Did I get near it? Quote whatever came closest. If nothing did, say so plainly.

3. THE STAFFING CONSEQUENCE. Did I find out that three women left night rotation and the account cannot be staffed? It is the strongest thing in the case.

4. THE TRAP. Did I ask anything that would have surfaced the information security review? If not, tell me plainly that I was about to promise a timeline that cannot happen.

5. THE TWO INTERRUPTIONS. Quote my first sentence in response to each and classify it: ACKNOWLEDGEMENT, QUESTION, EXPLANATION or ARGUMENT. On Routematic, did I ask why it did not go anywhere?

6. THE PITCH. Quote my Problem section. Did it describe your world or the product?

7. QUALIFICATION. Go through MEDDICC — Metrics, Economic buyer, Decision criteria, Decision process, Identify pain, Champion, Competition — and say for each what I established, quoting the evidence, or write NOT ASKED.

8. THE CLOSE. Was the ask something I could agree to alone? Quote it.

9. OBJECTIONS. List every objection or concern I raised, in my words. I will need this list.

—— END OF PROMPT ——

Deliverable 5 — The Content Plan

You have just heard a set of objections. So has every other seller at MoveInSync, on every deal like this one. Some of those objections deserve a piece of content. Most do not.

THE DISTINCTION THIS DELIVERABLE TESTS

Content solves objections that recur across accounts. It cannot solve objections that are specific to one deal.

"Anand has been asking for two years, what has changed" is a Tersus problem. "How do we prove employee safety to a client with a contractual clause" is a category problem that every IT services company in India will have.

Marketing time spent on the first kind is wasted. Knowing which is which is the job.

5.1 Sort your objections

The objection, in her words	Deal-specific or category-wide?	Why

5.2 The brief for marketing

Two assets. No more. For each, fill every row — a brief that does not say what the asset must prove is not a brief.

	Asset 1	Asset 2
The objection it answers		
Format, and why that format		
Who reads it — name the role		
Where in the funnel it gets used		
What it has to prove, specifically		
What evidence we need that we do not have yet		

	Asset 1	Asset 2
How we would know it worked		

THE ROW PEOPLE SKIP

'What evidence we need that we do not have yet.'

Most content briefs assume the proof exists. It usually does not, and the honest answer here is often a customer reference nobody has asked for yet, or a number nobody has calculated. Naming that gap is more useful to marketing than the asset itself.

Deliverable 6 — The GTM Plan

THE TARGET

MoveInSync wants Rs 30 crore of new revenue next year from the segment Tersus belongs to — Indian companies with large shift-based workforces.

Work backwards. Build the funnel that produces it, state every assumption, and say when outreach has to start.

6.1 What you know

	Detail
The universe	Roughly 1,200 companies in India with 2,000+ employees running night or rotating shifts — IT services, GCCs, BPO, healthcare, large manufacturing.
Already customers	300+ of them, including 72 Fortune 500 companies.
Deal size	Rs 40 lakh to Rs 3 crore a year. Assume an Rs 80 lakh average unless you argue otherwise.
Cycle	Median six months, range four to nine.
The team	Six account executives and four SDRs. No budget to expand it this year.
Every deal	Goes through an information security review at the buyer's end.

6.2 Build the model

Working backwards	Your number	The assumption behind it
Revenue target		
Average deal size		
Deals needed		
Qualified opportunities needed		
First meetings needed		
Accounts that must be worked		
Contacts per account		

6.3 Four questions

Question	Your answer
How many accounts are left that are not already customers? What proportion of them would have to close to hit the target?	
Your team can work a limited number of accounts properly. Pick a number, justify it, and say what new-logo revenue that actually produces.	
If that number is short of Rs 30 crore, where does the rest come from? Be specific about how much and from where.	
With a six-month median cycle, when does outreach have to start for revenue to land in Q3 and Q4? Give months.	

BEFORE YOU START

There is no arithmetic trick here and the numbers are not hidden. Everything you need is in 6.1.

Some of you will produce a model that requires contacting more companies than exist in India. If that happens, do not adjust the conversion rates until it works — write down what the model is telling you. That is the finding.

IN CLASS

One hour · bring your six deliverables

The Hour

Time	What we do	What you need in front of you
0-08	Jobs to be done. Three emotional job statements go on the board and we argue about which is a feeling and which is a budget line.	Deliverable 1
08-18	Buyer journey. Whose journey did you map? Most of you mapped one person's.	Deliverable 2
18-32	The call. Depth scores collected. Two things get named: the staffing consequence, and the review nobody asked about.	Deliverable 4 feedback, unedited
32-42	Content plan. Which objections deserve content and which are one deal's problem.	Deliverable 5
42-56	The GTM model. Your numbers go on the board. They will not agree, and the disagreement is the lesson.	Deliverable 6
56-60	Close.	—

HOW TO BE USEFUL IN THIS HOUR

Bring the version you actually produced, not a cleaned-up one. The wrong answers are more useful to the room than the right ones and everybody's GTM model is wrong in roughly the same place.

If your call went badly, say so early. Somebody has to, and the person who does gets the most out of the session.